DANCING WITH DURGA DEVI

Devotion with a Spine

A Navratri Sādhana Companion by Sheetal Kandola



9 nights of Devi • Shakti Embodiment • Somatics • Shadow work • Sensuality • Sovereignty

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Welcome to **Dancing with Durga Devī: Devotion with a Spine, Devī G**

This is an invitation to enter relationship with Devī through the body, devotion, movement, mantra, sensation, shadow work, desire and sovereignty.

Across these 9 nights, we journey through nine manifestations of Maa Durgā, allowing each form to become a mirror, a teaching and an embodied practice. This is not simply a study of 9 goddesses. It is an invitation to meet Her through your own lived experience. Let your sādhana become a living relationship between you, your body and Devi.

Why Navratri?

Hindu tradition recognizes four Navratris throughout the year, each occurring according to the lunar calendar:

- Māgha Navratri(Gupt) | January–February
- Chaitra Navratri | March–April
- Āṣāḍha Navratri (Gupt)| June–July
- Śarad Navratri | September–October

Śharad Navratri marks the transition into autumn and is one of the most widely observed periods of Devi worship. Seasonal transitions have long been understood in Indian traditions as powerful thresholds. Nature is changing, and therefore the human body, mind and prāṇa are also considered more receptive to change.

The outer transition becomes an invitation for an inner transition. As nature moves from one state into another, we too are given an opportunity to move from unconsciousness toward awareness, from stagnation toward movement, and from fragmentation toward integration. This is one reason Navratri is regarded as an especially potent time for sādhana, intentional spiritual practice.

Śakti: The Power That Moves Through Everything

In Śākta traditions, Śakti is not merely a goddess who possesses power. She is Power itself. She is the dynamic force through which consciousness becomes manifest.

Everything that moves, changes, creates, nourishes and transforms is an expression of Śakti. Śiva is described as pure, unmoving consciousness. Without Śakti, that consciousness remains inert. Śakti is the dynamic principle that allows consciousness to move, create, experience and become embodied.

When we turn toward Durgā during Navratri, we are not simply worshipping a figure outside ourselves. We are turning toward the cosmic intelligence of Śakti already moving through us as courage, discernment, creativity, nourishment, protection, desire, movement, transformation and spiritual awakening.

9 Nights as an Inner Journey

The most accessible way to understand Navratri is through the Navadurgā, the nine manifestations of Durgā worshipped across the nine nights. But the nine nights can also be understood as an inner journey through increasingly subtle dimensions of consciousness.

We begin with what is most tangible and embodied: the body, our environment, our habits, our actions and the ways we have learned to move through the world.

From there, the journey moves inward. We encounter mental and emotional layers of experience: fear, anger, attachment, insecurity, desire, grief and the patterns that keep us bound.

Gradually, the practice moves toward what is more subtle. We begin to recognize the consciousness beneath the patterns and experience Śakti not simply as something we invoke, but as the living intelligence moving through our own being.

Body → mind → emotion → shadow → awareness → embodiment

Our practice together will therefore not be purely intellectual. We will learn through movement, sensation, mantra, meditation, reflection, devotion and direct experience.

Why 9 Nights?

The number 9 is a perfect number and represents the unified field. 9 relates to Aries, which is connected to the planet, Mars. Mars is the planet of transformation and can realign you towards your Dharma focus but cutting away all that is no longer necessary or serving your highest self. The 9 lunar phases represent 9 steps the Divine Mother takes towards us. Also, it represents the 9 chakras, energy centers, in your body and each day in your body can represent the upward ascent of Kundalini Shakti.

The Darkness as Womb

In Tantric traditions, night can become a particularly powerful period for mantra and sādhana. Darkness is not simply the absence of light. It is the womb of transformation.

Just as a seed germinates unseen beneath the soil, spiritual transformation often happens in an interior space that is invisible to the outside world. What is changing within us may not yet be visible. Beneath the surface, something is taking root and preparing to emerge.

For 9 nights, we enter a period of intentional inwardness and allow ourselves to be transformed through the worship of Śakti, the Divine Feminine as the power that creates, sustains, protects, destroys and ultimately liberates.

Mā Durgā & Mahīṣāsura



The story of Mā Durgā and Mahīṣāsura is one of the central stories behind Śharad Navratri. According to the Devī Māhātmya, Mahīṣāsura was a powerful asura who performed intense tapas and received a boon that made him extraordinarily difficult to defeat. Empowered by this protection, he became increasingly arrogant and began conquering the worlds.

He defeated the devas and eventually took control of Svarga, the celestial realm. The gods found themselves powerless before him.

Mahīṣāsura, the buffalo asura, could change form during battle, appearing as a buffalo, lion, elephant, human and other forms. Unable to defeat him individually, the devas came together and combined their divine powers. From this unified Śakti, Mā Durgā manifested.

Durgā manifests as the unified power of the Divine.

Each deity offers Durgā a weapon:

- Śiva offers the trident
- Viṣṇu offers the Sudarśana Chakra
- Indra offers the Vajra
- Varuṇa offers the conch
- Agni offers divine weapons
- Vāyu offers the bow and arrows
- Himavān offers the lion as Her vehicle

Durgā enters the battle against Mahīṣāsura and his army. He continues changing forms, but Durgā remains unwavering. Eventually, as he emerges from his buffalo form, Durgā subdues and destroys him. She is celebrated as Mahīṣāsuramardinī, She who destroys Mahīṣāsura.

Mahīṣāsura Within Us

The story can also be approached psychologically. Mahīṣāsura becomes a metaphor for unconsciousness, inertia and egoic force. The buffalo represents consciousness that has become heavy, resistant and difficult to move.

He keeps changing forms. And so do our inner obstacles. We overcome one pattern, only to discover another one underneath.

Fear becomes anger. Anger becomes pride. Pride becomes attachment. Attachment becomes insecurity. Insecurity becomes control. Control becomes another form of fear.

The form changes, but the underlying pattern remains.

The battle of Durgā is therefore not simply a battle against one demon. It becomes an invitation to confront avidyā, the fundamental ignorance of our true nature.

What is beneath the pattern? What are we not yet seeing? What would become possible if we stopped identifying with the pattern?

The 3 Great Movements of Śakti

The story of Durgā and Mahīṣāsura leads us into the three great movements of Śakti represented through Durgā, Lakṣmī and Sarasvatī.

Maa Durgā/Maa Kali: TRANSFORMATION

Durgā represents transformation and the removal of obstruction. First, we must clear. We confront what no longer serves us: fear, inertia, destructive patterns, attachments, limiting beliefs and the unconscious forces that keep us bound.

Sri Lakṣmī: Cultivate

Once that inner space has been cleared, we turn toward Lakṣmī, who represents nourishment, abundance, beauty and auspiciousness. We consciously nourish what we want to flourish: health, prosperity, beauty, relationships, generosity, gratitude, pleasure and auspiciousness.

Sarasvatī Shakti: Refine & Realize

Finally, we move toward Sarasvatī, who represents knowledge, wisdom and realization. We move beyond merely acquiring things and begin seeking vidyā, knowledge that transforms consciousness.

TRANSFORM. CULTIVATE. REFINE/REALIZE.

We clear the vessel. We fill the vessel with what nourishes life. And ultimately, we become receptive enough to recognize what has been moving through the vessel all along. This is why Navratri is about becoming a more receptive vessel for Śakti.

Vijayadaśamī: The 10TH Day

Vijayadaśamī marks victory. After nine nights of practice, purification, confrontation, devotion and transformation, we arrive at the symbolic victory of consciousness over the forces that keep us bound. The victory is not simply over something outside ourselves. It is victory over everything within us that prevents us from living from our deepest awareness.

The victory is not: "I defeated my darkness." It is: "I learned to see through it."

Creating Your Sacred Space

Before we begin, create a small space in your home where you can meet Devi each day. Your altar does not need to be elaborate. Simple and sincere is enough.

Ideally, an altar to the Divine Feminine can be placed against the East wall, with North or Northeast as secondary possibilities. If your altar is on the East wall, you face East during your sādhana and the mūrti faces West. If your altar is on the North wall, you face North and the mūrti faces South.

If your home does not allow this arrangement, do not let logistics become an obstacle to devotion. The relationship matters more than perfection.

Keep the altar area clean and create a comfortable place for yourself to sit, such as a firm cushion or folded blanket.

Always place a cloth beneath a mūrti or sacred form. You may use one cloth across the entire altar or several smaller cloths. When possible, choose a natural fiber such as silk, linen, cotton or wool.

Your altar can evolve. It may become more elaborate or more minimal as your relationship with Devi and your sādhana change. A simple altar may contain a mūrti, a framed image, or an object from nature that evokes the Divine.

Altar Items & the 5 Elements

- A cloth beneath the mūrti and covering the altar surface
- A bell to ring at the start of devotional practice
- Incense or essential oils
- A flame: ghee lamp or candle
- A small bowl of turmeric or kumkum, or a few stones
- A small bowl of fresh water or milk
- Flowers
- Sweets, dried or fresh fruit, or nuts such as cashews
- Your printed mantra or book for recitation (invitation to keep a journal nearby for contemplation, insights and reflection.)

9 ways co-participate with Shakti during Navratri

1. Hold a Sacred Sankalpa

Ask the Divine Mother for the support you need, and choose a **Sankalpa**: a deep vow or commitment that you are ready to embody. Write it down. Place it on your altar. Speak it aloud. Return to it each day.Your Sankalpa might be: **"I commit to trusting my body and honoring what I truly need."**
"I am devoted to creating a life rooted in love, sovereignty, and purpose."

Allow your Sankalpa become the thread that guides your Navratri.

2. Create a Sacred Space

Create an altar or sacred space that represents your relationship with Devi.You may include an image or murti of the Goddess, a candle or diya, flowers, fruit, water, incense, or something personally meaningful.You don't need anything elaborate. The purpose is to create a physical space where you can **pause, focus your attention, make offerings, and remember what is sacred.**

3. Practice Shakti Waterfall

Move energy through the body using **touch, breath, movement, shaking, and sound**.Allow the body to soften, expand, release, and express. Rather than trying to perform the practice perfectly, listen to sensation and let your body guide you.

(Free Shakti Waterfall embodiment practice video available through Sri Shakti Shala.)

4. Chant Devi Mantras

Work with a Devi mantra such as: **Om Dum Durgāyai Namaḥ**

Practice at sunrise, sunset, or any time you can be fully present. Sit comfortably with a long spine, close your eyes, and allow the repetition to become rhythmic. Chant in multiples of **9 or 108x**, allowing the vibration and repetition to settle into the body.

5. Practice Slowness + Rest

Navratri is also an invitation to **slow down enough to listen**. Rest. Soften. Reduce unnecessary stimulation. Notice your breath, your sensations, your emotions, and the subtle messages of your body. Before immediately asking, *"What should I do?"*, practice asking:

"What is my body asking for?"

Shakti is both **movement and stillness, expression and receptivity.**

6. Make a Consistent Effort

Choose one simple practice that helps you consciously align with the energy of Shakti each day. It might be fasting, yoga, meditation, chanting, movement, prayer, nourishing your body, or speaking with greater kindness. The practice itself matters less than your **sincerity and consistency**. You are building a relationship, not trying to achieve perfection.

7. Observe the Energy

Create moments of silence to listen and observe what is moving through you. Meditate. Journal. Notice your emotions, sensations, dreams, resistance, desires, and insights.

At the end of each day, you might ask: **What is being revealed? What am I being asked to release? What wants to emerge through me?** Allow Navratri become a conversation between you and the Goddess.

8. Distribute the Energy

Let your devotion move beyond yourself.

Offer kindness. Feed someone. Support another woman. Mentor a girl. Give generously. Donate to organizations supporting women and girls. Ask yourself:" **How can the Shakti I cultivate within myself become nourishment for someone else?"** Devotion becomes powerful when it moves into action.

9. Celebrate Your Victory

At the culmination of Navratri, pause and acknowledge what has shifted. Return to your Sankalpa and envision the next **six months** as a period of its unfolding.

What are you calling into form?
What chapter are you entering?
What are you ready to leave behind?

Celebrate the life you are choosing to create.

Let your Sankalpa be the seed.
Let your practice be the water.
Let your life become the place where Shakti blossoms. 🌹

The Navadurgā

Nine manifestations of Durgā, approached as devotional and embodied doorways.



1. Śailaputrī | The Daughter of the Mountain

Śailaputrī invites us into foundation, grounding, stability and connection with Earth.

Devotional focus: Create a clean altar; work with flowers; offer milk, ghee or sweets; connect with Earth; spend time in nature; work with the root center; recite mantra.

Reflection: What am I building my life upon? Where does my body know that it is safe enough to root?

2. Brahmacāriṇī | The One Who Walks the Path of Devotion

Brahmacāriṇī carries qualities of discipline, study, focus and devotion.

Devotional focus: Light a ghee lamp or candle; offer flowers; offer kumkum or sindoor; commit to sādhana; deepen sacred study; work with mantra.

Reflection: What am I devoted to? What becomes possible when my energy stops scattering?

3. Candraghaṇṭā | The Bell of the Moon

Candraghaṇṭā is associated with harmony, relationship, sensuality and courage.

Devotional focus: Ring a ritual bell; chant mantra aloud; dress beautifully for sādhana; offer flowers; work with devotional sound.

Reflection: What does harmony feel like in my body? Can I remain connected to myself while opening to another?

4. Kūṣmāṇḍā | The Cosmic Womb

Kūṣmāṇḍā is connected with creation, creativity, prosperity, vitality and the womb.

Devotional focus: Offer round foods such as pumpkin or squash, or seasonal fruit; offer honey or saffron; offer orange or yellow flowers; create warmth and beauty; bring light and fire into your space.

Reflection: What wants to be created through me? Where can I bring more warmth into my life?

5. Skandamātā | The Mother

Skandamātā invites us into mothering, protection, nourishment and compassion.

Devotional focus: Write prayers; speak loving words; reach toward maternal figures; chant with loving bhāva; offer fruits, rice, pudding or sweets; practice nourishment.

Reflection: How do I receive care? How do I offer care without abandoning myself? What does my inner mother need from me?

6. Kātyāyanī | The Warrior of Purpose

Kātyāyanī brings clarity, courage, purpose and the removal of obstacles.

Devotional focus: Meditate on the third eye; ask for clarity and courage; offer honey, kumkum or turmeric, incense, red flowers or roses; recite mantra.

Reflection: What am I no longer willing to negotiate with? Where is Devi asking me to become more courageous?

7. Kālarātrī | The Dark Night of Devi

Kālarātrī is the fierce face of the Goddess, inviting us to meet shadow and return to sovereignty.

Devotional focus: Offer jaggery or sesame seeds; offer dark red or blue flowers; offer sandalwood; light a ghee or mustard-oil lamp; purify with incense; offer mantra.

Reflection: What shadow am I ready to face? What have I mistaken for my identity that I am now ready to release?

8. Mahāgaurī | The Radiant One

Mahāgaurī carries qualities of purity, fullness, satisfaction, inclusivity and auspicious blessing.

Devotional focus: Offer white flowers, coconut, rice pudding, seasonal fruit or sweets; wear white; practice generosity.

Reflection: What happens when I stop believing I need to become someone else to be worthy? Where can I allow myself to receive?

9. Siddhidātrī | The Giver of Siddhis

Siddhidātrī represents knowledge, mastery, spiritual fulfillment and the fruits of sādhana.

Devotional focus: Offer sweets, jaggery, sesame halwa or fruit; offer pink, red or white flowers; place books on the altar for blessing; give books or knowledge to others; offer mantra.

Reflection: What wisdom has this journey revealed? What am I now capable of receiving, embodying and sharing?

Your Daily Sādhana

You do not need to create a complicated ritual. Before each practice, take a moment to arrive.

Light your candle or lamp. Ring your bell. Offer your flowers. Feel your feet. Feel your breath. Look at Devi.

Then ask:

"What is Devi inviting me to meet today?"

Let your practice move beyond the intellectual. Feel Her. Move with Her. Listen for Her. Let Her teach you through your own body.

When the practice is complete, take a few moments to journal:

In my body:

_____

_____

In my emotions:

_____

_____

In my desires:

_____

_____

In my shadows:

_____

_____

What Devi is asking of me:

_____

_____

Sanskrit & Devotional Vocabulary

These words carry layers of meaning. Use this glossary as a reference as you encounter the language of sādhana and devotion throughout the container.

The Elements

Ākāśa	Space / ether
Agni	Fire
Āpaḥ	Water
Jala	Water
Pṛthvī	Earth
Vāyu	Air
Mahābhūta	The five great elements: Earth, Water, Fire, Air and Space.
Devī	The feminine divine form.
Deva	The masculine divine form.
Devatā	A divine form that can be worshipped, related to and entered into relationship with.
Durgā Mā / Durgā Devī	A feminine divine form associated with transformation and the dissolution of forces that obstruct us on the path of life and spiritual growth.

Lakṣmī Mā / Lakṣmī Devī	A feminine divine form associated with abundance, beauty and sustenance.
Sarasvatī Mā / Sarasvatī Devī	A feminine divine form associated with knowledge, language, sound, wisdom and independent bliss.
Iṣṭadevatā	One's own preferred, cherished or chosen Devatā.
Sādhana	One's personal spiritual practice, such as mantra sādhana.
Pūjā	An organized act of worship that engages the five elements.
Mantra	A sacred sound or phrase used as a device for the mind, carrying both sound and meaning.
Mūrti	A devotional form representing or symbolizing your object of adoration or sādhana. A mūrti may be a statue or image and can be made from stone, metal, clay or other materials.
Chandi Pāṭha / Devī Māhātmya	A sacred Sanskrit text containing the stories, teachings and blessings of Devī, traditionally recited through mantra.
Mahīṣa / Mahīṣāsura	The shape-shifting asura who is slain by Durgā.
Asura	Forces that obstruct dharma, abundance or goodness.
Daiva	Divine force that promotes dharma.

A Note on Language

Sanskrit is not simply a vocabulary to memorize. These words point toward relationships, practices and ways of perceiving.

As you encounter them throughout Navratri, allow yourself to learn them through sound, repetition, ritual, movement and lived experience. You do not have to know everything intellectually before you begin.

A Final Offering

You do not have to perform devotion perfectly. Your altar can be beautiful or bare. Your mantra can be whispered or sung. Your practice can last an hour or five minutes.

What matters is that you show up in relationship.

Relationship with Devi. Relationship with your body. Relationship with your power. Relationship with your shadow. Relationship with your desire. Relationship with the parts of yourself you have learned to suppress, fear or abandon.

Navratri gives us nine nights to remember that Śakti is not merely something we worship outside ourselves. She is also the intelligence moving through our bodies, our boundaries, our desires, our grief, our pleasure, our courage and our capacity to create.

This is Devotion with a Spine!



Glory to the Goddess!

Jai Mā Durgā

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